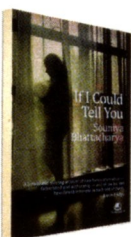


Heartbreak STATION

A first novelist's bleak vision of how love blunders is steeped in self-consciousness

By Brinda Bose



IF I COULD
TELL YOU
by SOUMYA
BHATTACHARYA
Tranquebar
Price: Rs 350
Pages: 200

Soumya Bhattacharya, we are told in his blog, has a book habit—like a drug habit. In a way (and I mean it in a complimentary way), this is the overwhelming impression we are left with at the end of his first novel: here is a writer whose sensibility has been wrought and honed passionately as well as assiduously by his reading of English fiction; and here is one, also, who is (literally, metaphorically, emotionally—and relentlessly) an author in search of a book. His own, of course. And through it, perhaps, all the books he has ever read, and then, those he might ever wish to read.

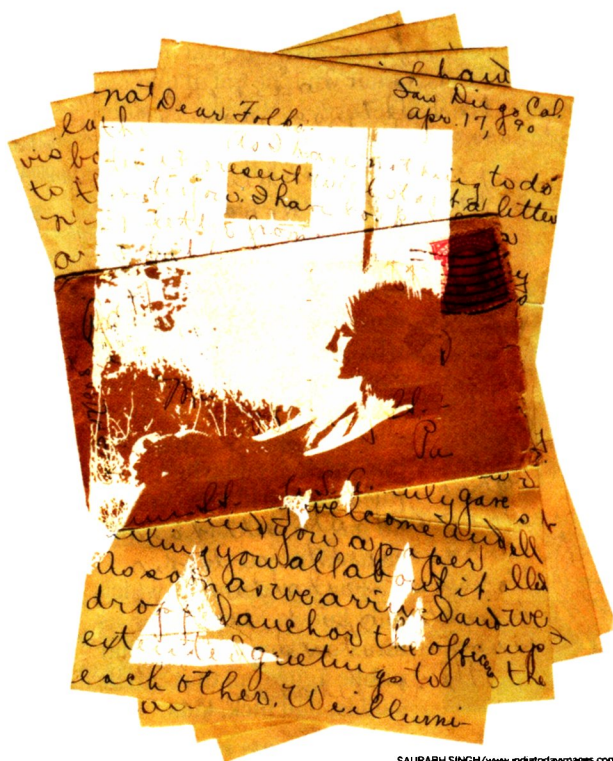
And therein lies the rub. As any reader and writer worth those salts will know, this is the profile of an overreacher. What remains Bhattacharya's singular strength is his ability to amass wisdom culled from a range of eclectic reading and to spit them out along with the butt-ends of his days and ways with an uncommon and lucid charm. With understudied grace he is able to assault both our senses (recording moments of

immaculate delight and unbearable sadness) and our memory (of the days of our lives, but also of our own readings, and the truths we too may have distilled from them). What threatens to become an albatross around the neck of his novel is a pervasive self-consciousness, however, that drops a shadow between the motion and the act of writing in itself.

If I Could Tell You is not autobiographical except in that the little girl at the heart of the tale carries the name (and presumably some of the sugar and spice) of his daughter Oishi. We, who already know Oishi from this journalist-writer's column on parenting in a national newspaper, may be forgiven for confusing the wood for the trees in her fictional avatar. As the novel unfolds through letters from a father to a daughter, however, we begin to hope that it is anything but autobiographical; Bhattacharya's clarification in an interview that it is "a novel in the guise of a confession, rather than a confession in the guise of a novel" foment relief, a relief that is perhaps the most potent sign of how viscerally destabilising the unfolding story is.

Almost disarmingly simple in its telling as befitting a tale told to a young, beloved child, Bhattacharya's bleak vision of how love blunders and bludgeons yet carries the tragic wisdom of an Auden—"Time will say nothing but I told you so/Time only knows the price I have to pay/If I could tell you I would let you know"—as well as the compelling harshness of contemporary realities, what the crash of financial markets and the sudden, shocking ebb of stocks and shares in an India earlier ebullient with a soaring economy and an astonishingly upbeat polity might do to a sensibility that is fixated on doing its own thing (reading and writing and parenting, in an interchangeable order of importance).

Here is a tale of lives that start with the twinkling promise of smiling stars, and then twists gruesomely out of shape in a heartbeat. There is death, heartbreak and the shadow of another death. But there is yet an abiding hope at the bottom of the pot if you can scrape it hard and long enough, in a father's devotion to his daughter, because the Audenesque poetic gloss tells us, of course, that he does what he does because he loves her more than he can say. ■



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